managed to edge considerably closer to unravelling the complex plot behind the shocking crime that stunned the nation.

The exhaustive investigation process and interrogation of key suspects picked up so far have established that the plot to kill Rajiv Gandhi was first hatched in October 1990 deep in the jungles of Jaffna. The motive is now understood to have been related to the political tremors then emanating from New Delhi. The then Prime Minister V.P. Singh was battling for survival following a threat by the BJP to withdraw support to his minority National Front government.

Across the Palk Strait, in the forest hideouts of Jaffna in north-eastern Sri Lanka, the LTTE leadership met for a crucial assessment of the situation. The meeting decided that the chances of Congress (I) president Rajiv Gandhi returning to power were now almost certain. For the extremist organization struggling for Tamil Eelam, this meant a possible re-induction of the IPKF in Sri Lanka and a certain crackdown on the elaborate LTTE network established in Tamil Nadu.

Even before the National Front government finally collapsed, the LTTE had made up its mind to prevent Rajiv Gandhi from regaining power even if it required the ultimate deterrent - his assassination. By early November 1990, the V.P. Singh government was voted out and Rajiv Gandhi was virtually back in power, shooting from behind Chandra Shekhar’s shoulder. The possibility of a mid-term poll loomed ever larger. The LTTE was getting desperate.

Estimating it would be next to impossible to target Rajiv once he becomes the Prime Minister, the LTTE decided to strike before that, at a time when security status was much lower and what could be a better location than an election rally where Rajiv will be surrounded by crowd leaving him more vulnerable. By the end of November 1990, Prabhakaran called a meeting of four key people who he thought would be best to carry out the task of